



BREATHING

You must breathe all the time to stay alive. If you try to hold your breath for more than about a minute, your body will force you to start breathing again. The air that you breathe is made up of many different gases mixed together, but your body only needs one of them, oxygen, to keep you alive. If you ran out of oxygen, even for a very short time, you would die. The air you breathe goes into two soft, moist sponges, called lungs. You have one on each side of your chest.

Lung capacity

Breathe in deeply. Blow into a balloon until you run out of breath. Tie a knot in the balloon. Now you can see just how much air your lungs are able to hold.



Bad breath!

The air that you breathe can contain things that are bad for you. This woman is wearing a mask to protect herself from car fumes.

Blood vessels surround the alveoli.

Alveoli are stretchy, so they can blow up like balloons. Gases can pass right through the alveoli's stretched skin.

Oxygen seeps from the alveoli into the blood. A waste gas, called carbon dioxide, seeps from the blood back into the alveoli to be breathed out.

Some air is always left in your lungs because they would collapse if they were completely empty.

Right lung

Bronchus

Heart

